Besides, here I was interacting with the government much more actively than the Reserve Bank staff had been used to seeing. Would they give me the benefit of the doubt and evaluate my actions in the context of the crisis? Or would they write me off as someone who couldn't stand up to pressure from the government?

The senior officers' retreat of the Reserve Bank in late November 2008 presented a much-needed opportunity for me to open up with the senior management and speak to them candidly about my concerns and anxieties, and also about my positions vis-à-vis the government. This retreat is a standard feature on the Reserve Bank's annual calendar when all the senior staff, from the governor down to the chief general manager, maybe about one hundred in all, go offsite for a couple of days to learn, understand, bond and rejuvenate.

I spoke without any notes which—as the Reserve Bank's staff would learn as they got to know me better—was very uncharacteristic of me. I also spoke without any specific narrative in my mind. I levelled with them on the process leading to my appointment, on the complexity of the crisis, and my journey up the learning curve. I drew their attention to what was happening everywhere around the world—governments and central banks were coordinating as never before to fight the crisis. What was happening in India, I told them, was in tune with that pattern. It was only the special circumstances surrounding me—my background in the government and my relative 'unknownness'—that were fuelling these misperceptions. While I could live with the negative press, I could not live with an institution that was suspicious of me. As I concluded, I requested them to help transmit this message to the entire staff of the Reserve Bank, not all of whom were able to fully appreciate the unusual circumstances brought on by the crisis.

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The criticism on both strands—inadequate communication and not acting independently—waned and eventually disappeared as the calendar turned to 2009. The broad thrust of the media evaluation of the first 100 days of my